



Association of ERC Grantees

Association of ERC Grantees

Action Plan

in Fulfilment of the Commitments of the
Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

v1.2 (02.10.2024)

As a signatory of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA), the Association of ERC Grantees (AERG) is dedicated to fulfilling its associated ten commitments. However, due to the nature of AERG and its member selection criteria, we do not independently evaluate research or researchers.

Research Assessment at the AERG

The Association of ERC Grantees is a membership organization for principal investigators funded by the European Research Council (ERC), whereby a successful grant application automatically entitles an individual researcher to become a member of AERG. We therefore do not independently evaluate research or researchers directly but rely on the evaluation conducted by the expert peer evaluation panels of the ERC.

For this reason, the four main commitments of ARRA do not directly apply to the AERG, apart from our role in advocating for and support of reforms of the ERC's internal evaluation practices. For some of the six supporting commitments, on the other hand, we have a more direct role to play, as outlined below.

Core Commitments

The Agreement is based on four core commitments:

1. *Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and the nature of the research*
2. *Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer-review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators*
3. *Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index*
4. *Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment*

The AERG does not evaluate research or researchers directly, and thus neither can it directly apply Commitments 1 and 2, nor does it engage in the practices mentioned in Commitments 3 and 4. Therefore there are no reforms foreseen for AERG to fulfil the four core commitments.

Supporting Commitments

The Agreement includes six further Supporting Commitments:

5. *Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to*

No organizational changes are foreseen to be needed to fulfil our commitments, although the AERG will closely monitor the developments in this space and will adapt as needed accordingly.

6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes

The AERG does not directly develop criteria, tools or process, but does actively participate in discussions of these developments, as well as providing a researcher perspective into the reforms, including the CoARA Working Groups that do this work. The AERG also participated in the ERC workshop on reform of research assessment in 2022, which informed its own recent and highly laudable reforms.¹

7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

The AERG was one of the original signatories of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment, and thus has contributed to raising awareness and supporting the reforms both amongst its members and the broader research community.

In particular, the AERG Board of Directors includes the elected CoARA Steering Board (2022–2024) member Prof. Toma Susi amongst its ranks, who has given numerous talks on the importance and implementation of the reforms in recent years. Another AERG Board member Prof. Agnieszka Wykowska represents the Association in the ERA Forum, which has another crucial role to play in the reforms.

The AERG Board expects such activities to continue in the coming years.

8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

The AERG is a member of the CoARA Working Group “Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals”, contributing to the exchange of practices and mutual learning. Further Working Groups and other opportunities will be taken up as and when the AERG feels it can make an impactful contribution within the resources we have.

9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments

This Action Plan is the first concrete deliverable in fulfilment of this Commitment, and will be followed by periodic updates if needed, as well as the mandatory further report within five years of our signing the Agreement.

10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

No direct contribution to research on research, apart from potentially facilitating surveys of our membership touching on relevant issues, are foreseen.

¹ Maria Leptin, “Evaluation of research proposals: The why and what of the ERC's recent changes” (2024) <https://erc.europa.eu/news-events/news/evaluation-research-proposals-why-and-what-ercs-recent-changes>

Conclusion

The Association of ERC Grantees fully supports and aligns with the aims and Commitments of the Agreement for Reforming Research Assessment and the CoARA work more broadly. We particularly warmly welcome the recent well-justified changes made to the ERC evaluation processes, which align it with CoARA. We will continue to monitor and support these developments, and to seek out new ways to proactively contribute to the much-needed and long-overdue reforms.